JONATHAN ZEMPEL

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Summary

An accomplished design systems practitioner, specializing in resource-oriented design and analysis, robust micro-service architectures, lean thinking, dedication to code construction styled for readability, and software implementations tuned for performance. Repeatedly recognized for a broad range of technical competence, strong design instincts, an untiring dedication to mentoring and quality review, superb team leadership ability, and a keen awareness for inventing flexible product solutions catered to a wide variety of consumer demands.

Expertise

- *Technologies:* React, Vite, Storybook, Tailwind CSS
- *Languages:* TypeScript, HTML, CSS, Python, Java, SQL
- *Project Management:* JIRA, PivotalTracker
- *Design Tools:* Figma, Sketch
- *Development Tools:* git, vim, terminal

Professional Experience

Zendesk, Inc., San Francisco, CA **Apr '14 – Present**

Sr. Principal Engineer

Created the Zendesk Garden design system as a dedicated advocate for user experience. This comprehensive system helps teams deliver exceptional digital experiences. My focus on collaboration and innovation led to a design system that streamlines workflows and enhances product consistency and accessibility. Through careful research and user testing, I led a team to build a strong library of components and guidelines that promote best practices in UI/UX design. I worked closely with product managers, designers, and engineers to gather feedback and continuously improve the system. The result is a scalable, user-friendly design system that has greatly increased development efficiency and user satisfaction across all Zendesk products. My contributions fostered a culture of design thinking within the organization, making a lasting impact on Zendesk's product development approach. Leveraging Garden, I personally delivered the component set that informed Zendesk's 2026 unified navigation across eight products.

- Created Project: Garden (Figma & React) - the source of truth for tools, standards, and best practices when building products at Zendesk
- Built and led a cross-functional team of engineers and designers that maintained zero-regression core libraries
- Architected a federated contribution model that scaled Garden across dozens of globally distributed engineering teams
- Engineered custom static analysis tools and dependency tracking to measure Garden adoption, which grew to cover more than 95% of all UI interactions
- Spearheaded Zendesk's technical accessibility initiative, engineering WCAG 2.2 AA compliance directly into the primitive component layer to guarantee access for everyone across all product experiences

Pickwick & Weller, San Francisco, CA **Aug '12 – Apr '14**

Developer

Worked with a crack startup team in the fashion space where I obsessed over the design and construction of beautiful, pixel-perfect service APIs and elegant, opinionated web and mobile UIs.

- Leveraged jQM to create the entire mobile web experience
- Implemented redesign of the majority of the e-commerce site
- Shifted the development team from manual to a continuous deployment strategy
- Injected a custom CMS implementation used to serve user-generated content throughout the website
- Periodic ownership of social marketing campaigns
- Initiated the development of an internal graphical dashboard used to monitor sales and inventory
- Authored open-sourced Stamps.com and Fedex shipping APIs implemented for order fulfillment

Genomera, Inc., Palo Alto, CA **Feb '10 – Aug '12**

Architect

Responsible for the inception of an internet-scale, social application designed to modernize clinical trials - helping people use information about their DNA to answer health questions. Successfully combined lean startup techniques with agile development practices inside a swift moving, "fail fast" entrepreneurial environment.

- Built the entire website based on a HTML5+CSS+JavaScript, Python, and MongoDB stack
- Deployed to production multiple times per day, starting from day one
- Worked with the product team to implement a full site re-design
- Conducted numerous interviews to better understand application user delight and frustration